SWEDEN FIGHTS FOR DOMINATION

DURING THE 17th century Sweden established itself as a major power in Europe, especially through its wars with Poland and its prominent participation in the Thirty Years War (1618–48) in Germany. Swedish monarchs wanted a navy to match their great power status, but despite spending heavily on warship construction they found success at sea elusive, repeatedly depending upon the triumphs of their land forces to compensate for maritime failings. Denmark and Norway, united under the Danish crown since 1537, struggled to resist Swedish domination of the Baltic on land and at sea. The Dutch United Provinces at times gave support to Denmark because the Baltic was a prime source of trade and naval supplies to which they needed secure access. Their principle was to support whichever of the Scandinavian states was weakest, to prevent a naval power emerging that might control the Baltic at their expense. Despite the severe setbacks of the Scanian War (1675–78), which brought humiliating defeats for the Swedish navy at Öland and Kjöge Bay, Sweden remained the dominant power in the Baltic until the early 18th century.

DUTCH-SWEDISH WAR



BATTLE OF THE SOUND

Date	October 29, 1658
Location	The Oresund, off Copenhagen
Result	Dutch victory

COMBATANTS

DUTCH UNITED PROVINCES, DENMARK	SWEDEN

COMMANDERS

Jacob van Wassenaer	Karl Gustav Wrangel

FORCES

Ships: Dutch 35, Danes 7	**Ships:** 45

LOSSES

Men: 450 **Ships:** 2	**Men:** c.1,000 killed or wounded **Ships:** 5

THE BATTLE OF THE SOUND

For the Dutch United Provinces access to the Baltic for naval supplies and trade was commercially and militarily crucial. Sweden wished to exclude the Dutch from the Baltic by forcing the Danes to block their passage through the Oresund, the narrow sound between Denmark and Sweden. In 1658 Sweden's king Karl X Gustav put the Danish capital Copenhagen under siege by land and naval blockade. The Dutch sent a fleet to prevent the Swedes from defeating the Danes.

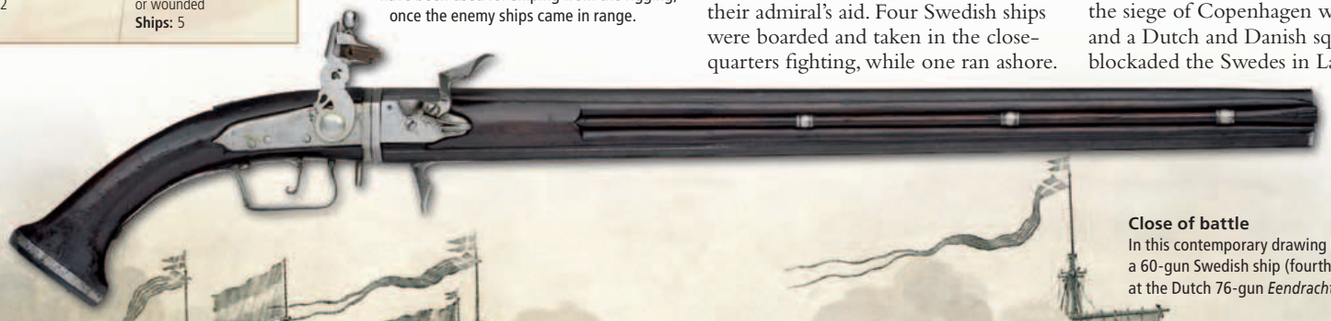
On the morning of October 29 a north wind allowed the Dutch commander Lieutenant Admiral Jacob van Wassenaer to sail into the Oresund and confront the Swedish blockade squadrons. There were seven Danish warships in Copenhagen, but they were unable to join the fighting because the wind that filled the Dutch sails kept them pinned in port. This left the Dutch substantially outgunned, with around 1,300 cannon to the Swedes' 1,600, although they could claim the advantage of being upwind.

A DISORDERED CONFLICT

Strong currents prevented ships maintaining much order on either side and a savage piecemeal battle ensued. Wassenaer's flagship *Eendracht* was surrounded by Swedish ships and took some heavy punishment, but was rescued by Dutch captains coming to their admiral's aid. Four Swedish ships were boarded and taken in the close-quarters fighting, while one ran ashore.

In the course of battle the Dutch lost one of their most famous—and controversial—admirals, the choleric and notoriously insubordinate Witte Cornelizoon de With. His flagship *Brederode* ran aground and, lying defenseless, was battered for two hours by enemy fire before being boarded. De With was injured by musket fire and died of his wounds—his embalmed body was exhibited by the Swedes as a trophy, before being returned to the Dutch for burial.

At around 2:00 p.m. the Dutch broke contact to sail into Copenhagen. The Swedes withdrew to the Swedish port of Landskrona. Both fleets were in a battered state and both claimed a victory. But the Dutch had achieved their objective, for the blockade and the siege of Copenhagen was lifted, and a Dutch and Danish squadron blockaded the Swedes in Landskrona.



Dutch double-barreled flintlock
Double-barreled flintlocks, like this, would have been used for sniping from the rigging, once the enemy ships came in range.



Close of battle
In this contemporary drawing by an eyewitness, a 60-gun Swedish ship (fourth from left) fires back at the Dutch 76-gun *Eendracht* as she passes by.